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Improving Product Discovery - Experiment 1

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Many institutions now try and adopt #ProductLeadGrowth strategies. Few get it right. Last October I talked about how Outcome Driven Innovation (ODI) can sharpen your precision in Product Discovery - but it can take a long time to execute properly. Who has time for that?

Fair. So this is the post about time.

Here's the constraint I keep running into. In discovery, the single most expensive and least repeatable input you have is the customer's attention. A 45-minute call with a partner's lead integrator is gold and you don't get a second take. If a third of it goes to re-confirming things you already had written down somewhere, you've burned a third of the most valuable resource in the whole exercise. So the real question isn't "who has time?" It's "how do I make every minute of that call buy *new* signal?"

On a recent API developer-experience study, I tried something. I put AI agents on the two ends of discovery that nobody enjoys: the **prep** before the call and the **synthesis** after it — and I kept the humans where humans add the value: in the conversation.

Before the Call: Do Your Homework

Just as you'd read up on a candidate before interviewing them, I had a Customer Interviewer Agent do the background on a partner first: who are they, what's their business, what product information sits on their website and in the developer forums? You don't want to spend valuable time with a customer asking what a Google search could have told you.

Then I pointed the agent at our internal notes, prior partnership notes, emails, a couple of earlier technical calls, and had it cross-reference all of that against the ten categories in our interview framework, section by section. Where did we already have the answer, and where were we flying blind?

Out of that it gave me two things:

- Every question we could already answer, pre-filled from the record and **clearly marked as "derived from our notes, not the partner's words."**
- A short checklist of only the real gaps left to probe live.

We never burned a minute re-asking something already sitting in a document, and every question I asked was one we couldn't answer any other way.

That "derived, not their words" tag matters more than it looks. The fastest way to corrupt a synthesis is to let your own assumptions get laundered into something that later reads like customer evidence. Keeping the agent strict about what was *assumed* versus what was *heard* is the same instinct as standardizing outcome statements in Part 1. It protects the data before you ever try to draw a conclusion from it.

One Framework, Applied Identically

We ran every partner against the same ten-category question set, from persona and core problem through workflow, error handling, performance, and what success looks like to them.

The sameness is deliberate. In Part 1 I described why we forced every ODI outcome statement into the same verb, "minimize": uniform phrasing is what let K-means find real clusters instead of noise. Interview frameworks are that idea one level up, where identical questions are what make eight conversations comparable at all. The agents stood up that structure and held it across every interview, and kept the raw verbatim notes strictly separate from any synthesis. Raw stays raw. You don't get to edit what someone said to make your pattern cleaner.

After the Calls: A Surprise Finding

This *isn't* the full ODI, but an experiment in abbreviation where the stakes are considerably lower. Could we simply use our few interviews to answer what the most acute pain-points are? **Could we base our action on data rather than intuition - even when we need to move extremely quickly?**

Eight conversations turned into one ~4,000-word cross-partner synthesis: a profile of each partner, a matrix of nine technical capabilities they did or didn't need from us, the recurring pain points, and a mapping of all of it back to the ODI questions we'd started with.

The framework we started with had four outcome areas. The synthesis argued for a fifth, a need that sat underneath nearly every conversation but that no single interview had named on its own. In ODI terms, a high-importance, under-satisfied outcome no individual customer put into words, because the pattern only lived *across* the set. That is exactly what discovery is supposed to surface, and the agent found it across the full set faster and more evenhandedly than I would at 11pm with eight tabs open.

I'll be precise about that, though. The agent didn't have the insight. It laid the evidence out cleanly, and tied it back to the questions faithfully, so the pattern was hard to miss. Assembling the case and making the call are different jobs, and it is worth keeping them separate. Don't let AI make the call for you, *it always says you're right.*

What This Doesn't Do

None of this replaces the customer or the interviewer. The conversation is still the most valuable part of the study. You're reading a hesitation, asking the follow-up nobody scripted, getting someone to trust you enough to hand over the real problem instead of the polite response. No checklist does that.

It won't fix a skewed sample either. Ours leaned heavily toward technically sophisticated integrators. The judgement calls, which unmet need matters most and what we do about it, still takes a good PM.

Conclusion

AI agents I developed don't change the ODI method; they lower the bar to play. Put them on the boring ends of discovery: **prep**, so you walk in already knowing everything the record can tell you, and **synthesis**, so the unmet need hiding across the whole sample doesn't slip past you. **Keep raw evidence separate** from synthesis, **mark assumptions** as assumptions. Then spend the minutes you saved where they're irreplaceable: in the conversation.

This wasn't an ODI study - but applying the interview and synthesis rigor from ODI got us good signal useful for early action.

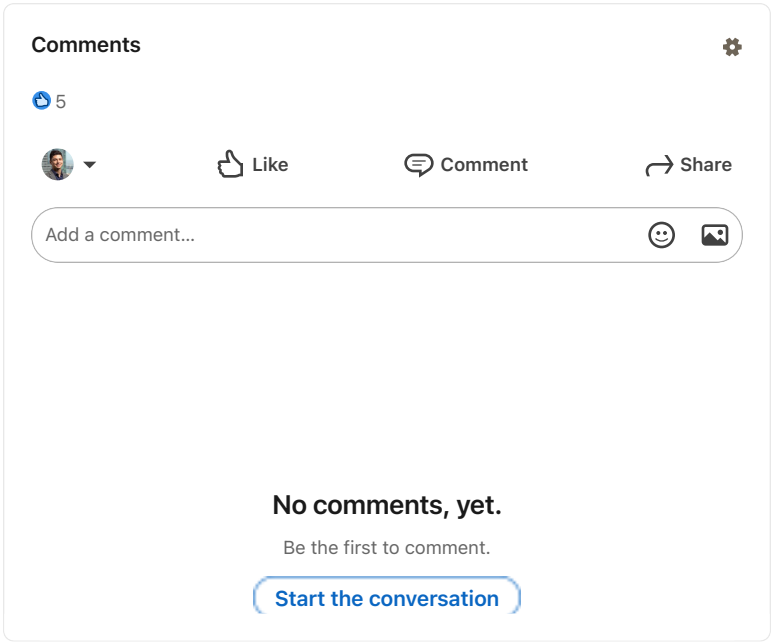
Further Reading

- O'Rorke, D. *Measurement & Action: How to ODI and JTBD Allow Data-Driven Innovation Before You Even Prototype* (Part 1).
- Ulwick, A. W. (2005). *What Customers Want: Using Outcome-Driven Innovation to Create Breakthrough Products and*

Services. Harvard Business School Press.

- Christensen, C. M., Hall, T., Dillon, K., & Duncan, D. S. (2016). *Competing Against Luck.* HarperBusiness.
- ODI Agentic System templates: **https://github.com/Daniel085/Product-Discovery-ODI/tree/claude/agentic-system-design-mnDWr**

PS: I owe much to the data-driven discovery culture from the Labs days at SendGrid, **Steve Sloan** and **Scott Williamson** *. The tools have changed enormously since then. The discipline they drilled into me hasn't. Keep on improving your craft!*





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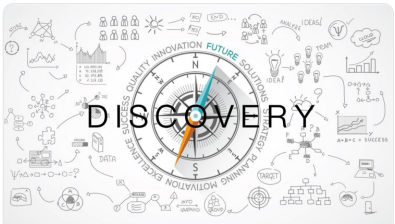
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